



SCHOOL OF EDUCATION **LIFE AND CAREER STUDIES** CALVIN UNIVERSITY

FACULTY GUIDEBOOK

WHAT IS THE LIFE AND CAREER STUDIES PROGRAM?

The Life and Career Studies (LCS) program is an inclusive, non-degree certificate program for students with intellectual or developmental disability. The LCS program has been operating on Calvin University's campus as the Ready for Life Academy since 2007.

Historically, the LCS program has been a guest partnership between the Ready for Life organization and Calvin University. In October 2020, Calvin University received a Transition and Postsecondary Programs for Students with Intellectual Disabilities (TPSID) grant from the United States Department of Education, which allowed for LCS to become an academic program. This transition brought about many exciting changes. LCS students now live in the residence halls, take college courses for audit credit, hold jobs on campus, and graduate from Calvin with a non-degree certificate in Life and Career Studies or Comprehensive Postsecondary Education.

The program learning outcomes for students enrolled in the LCS program are: 1) competitive employment; 2) independent living; 3) socialization; and 4) self-actualization. Students select their inclusive courses to support one or more of these learning outcomes.

MEANINGFUL PARTICIPATION

LCS student coursework may need to be modified to ensure **meaningful participation** (see *LCS Student Expectations*). Meaningful participation is determined individually with support from LCS instructional staff and articulated in the Academic Course Plan (see *Academic Course Plans*). The overall goal is for students to increase their knowledge over the course of the semester in their inclusive Calvin courses.

The LCS program does not expect professors to change their course format or materials to support an individual student; however, if you are interested, the LCS program offers annual Universal Design for Learning (UDL) professional learning opportunities. You can receive reimbursement for redesigning a portion of your course utilizing the principles of UDL. Please reach out to _____ to learn more about current opportunities.

ACADEMIC COURSE PLANS

LCS students earn audit credit for their courses, which counts toward completion of a non-degree certificate from Calvin University. To assist you with determining how to award credit for meaningful participation, students have an Academic Course Plan that clearly outlines what

successful engagement in a course looks like. Academic Course Plans are tailored to each student and course and address the following areas:

Attendance
Participation
Assignments (Quantity)
Assignments (Quality)

Individual student expectations will be clearly defined for each area of the Academic Course Plan. Student plans will be submitted directly to the professor at the beginning of the semester attached to the student's disability memo.

Academic Course Plans are the primary tool for determining whether LCS students have earned credit for your course. Meeting the expectations in three of four areas within the Academic Course Plan results in a "CR" grade for the course. For courses with Attendance and Participation expectations only (PER, music ensembles, etc.) meeting the expectation in both areas results in a "CR" grade for the course.

LCS STUDENT EXPECTATIONS

Most LCS students will complete modified coursework. Modifications to assignments will be suggested by the LCS instructors using the syllabus from your course. However, the LCS instructional staff welcome any input from you regarding course assignments and possible modifications. Please contact _____ with any suggestions for the Academic Course Plan.

The primary expectation for meaningful participation is for students to demonstrate growing understanding of the concepts taught in the course. To demonstrate their growth, many LCS students will submit a cumulative Google Slides project that will recap primary themes learned in the course and reflect on their own learning. The cumulative Google Slides project is designed to ensure meaningful participation and may replace a written final for the course. Still, some LCS students may take a standard final examination.

The LCS program hopes to build upon final examination options and encourages students and professors to explore other modified final options. Please reach out to _____ if interested in offering a modified final in a different format.

GRADING

LCS students should receive a grade of either "CR" or "NC" at the midterm, if applicable, and for the final grade of the term. Grades will be submitted electronically through Calvin's student grading system. In addition, because LCS students benefit from feedback regarding their strengths and areas for improvement, an additional request will be made at the midterm for a supplemental grading form to be completed. It will be sent to you from _____ via Google Forms and requests brief narrative feedback in all four areas of the Academic Course Plan. Students receive an exact copy of your comments. We hope that this is a place to provide encouragement and share any concerns regarding the student's performance in the course.

Completing the Google Form is not required, but it is strongly recommended. LCS students value your feedback. Furthermore, your feedback becomes even more critical when a student is not successfully engaging in the course at midterm. Comments on course participation and engagement allow LCS staff to identify appropriate supports needed for improvement toward earning a "CR" grade at the end of the semester.

ACADEMIC SUPPORT

LCS staff arrange for students to receive academic support frequently as they complete assignments for their inclusive courses. The level of support may vary according to the needs of the student and requirements of the course. Academic support may include, but is not limited to, tutoring, working with a peer, support for using accommodations, and/or guidance from LCS instructional staff.

PEER PARTNERS

The LCS program utilizes a research-based peer support model for student participation in inclusive courses. Each semester, Calvin students engage in over 1,000 hours of partnership with the LCS program. We actively recruit a peer partner, who is a degree-seeking student enrolled in your course, for each LCS enrollee. The peer partner serves as the LCS student's primary point of contact for the course. The LCS instructional staff will send an email prior to the start of the semester with additional information and requesting assistance in identifying a peer partner for your course.

There are many advantages to both the LCS student and the degree-seeking student in this peer arrangement. The selection of a peer partner gives the LCS student a primary "go-to" person for the course, allows them to build connections with peers outside of the LCS program, and offers needed assistance in a less stigmatizing manner. In addition, acting as a peer partner allows the degree-seeking student to develop problem-solving skills and grow academically and socially.

LCS staff welcome suggestions for modifications to our peer partnership model to best fit your course. Please contact _____ with these suggestions.

For more information on peer supports, please visit:
<https://www.erikwcarter.com/peermediated-supports>

MOODLE REQUEST

It is helpful to the LCS academic support coordinator, _____ to be added to your Moodle course as a tutor. Adding the academic support coordinator to Moodle allows them to better assist the LCS students in understanding and completing their coursework. The "tutor" role allows LCS staff to view the course without being in the gradebook. Directions are available [here](#).

SUPPORT FOR FACULTY AND STAFF

LCS staff are available to provide support and assistance as needed. Feel free to contact one of us with suggestions, questions, or concerns. Moreover, the LCS program at Calvin University provides additional learning opportunities to faculty and staff throughout the academic year. These opportunities are advertised in Calvin News. For example, the LCS program offers annual opportunities for additional training in Universal Design for Learning (UDL), which meets the requirement for Cultural Competency Professional Development (CCPD). Contact _____ if interested in learning more about current opportunities.

MEET THE PROGRAM STAFF

As a professor with an LCS student enrolled in your class, it will be helpful for you to become acquainted with the LCS program staff. Most communication will come directly from the instructional staff. Please feel free to reach out to them at any time regarding all student and coursework-specific suggestions, questions, or concerns. Program coordination staff are also available to answer questions, discuss concerns regarding the LCS program, and provide one-on-one training and support.

Instructional Staff: (Bios Included)

Administrative Staff: (Bios Included)

FAQs

Question: Who is a typical LCS student?

Answer: LCS students are Calvin students between the ages of 18-26 who have an intellectual or developmental disability. Students entering the LCS program have academic, employment, and independent living goals like their degree-seeking peers.

Question: What does meaningful participation mean?

Answer: The LCS program expects students to be actively engaged in their college courses. Although participation may look different for each student, all students are expected to attend their college courses regularly, be on time and prepared for class, and contribute to the classroom setting.

Question: What are the LCS program learning outcomes?

Answer: The LCS program learning outcomes are as follows:

Competitive Employment: Students who complete the program will be better prepared for the world of work having gained job seeking skills, a knowledge of work etiquette, and skills specific to their chosen specialty.

Independent Living: Through participating in a fully inclusive college experience, the students will gain independent living skills that will benefit them for self-determination of living arrangement.

Socialization: Through participating in a fully inclusive college experience, the students will gain interpersonal skills that will benefit them both vocationally and socially.

Self-Actualization: The very act of completing the coursework needed to receive the program will provide the students with a greater sense of self-worth and self-esteem. The students will have supports including partners, advisors, and program staff and resources; however, it will be expected that as they progress through the program, they will become increasingly more independent. This independence should expand beyond the college setting and into other aspects of their lives.

Question: How do I know the specific expectations of the LCS student in my classroom?

Answer: Each student will have an Academic Course Plan individually tailored to their strengths. Academic Course Plans outline classroom expectations in the following areas: Attendance, Participation, Assignments (Quantity), and Assignments (Quality). Students will share their Academic Course Plan along with their accommodation memo at the beginning of the semester. The Academic Course Plan is the primary tool for determining if the student has earned a "CR" grade for the course.

Question: What assignments will an LCS student complete?

Answer: Assignment expectations are determined for each student individually. Some students complete modified course work, with modifications made by the LCS instructional staff, while others complete traditional coursework as assigned. Assignment expectations are outlined in the Academic Course Plan.

Most LCS students will complete an alternative final project instead of a standard final examination. One example is a cumulative Google Slide project which would recap primary themes learned from the course and include personal reflection on learning.

Question: How should LCS students be graded?

Answer: LCS students earn audit credit in their courses and should be awarded a "CR" or "NC" grade at the midterm, if applicable, and the end of the semester. The grade assigned will depend on whether the student has met three of the four criteria on their Academic Course Plan. In addition, a Google Form requesting feedback is sent to all professors working with an LCS student during midterm. Completion of the Google Form is not required but is strongly recommended, as it allows for additional feedback on the LCS student's performance in the course.

Grading on assignments throughout the semester is conducted at the discretion of the professor. Previously, professors have graded assignments using a traditional grading scale, a CR/NC scale, or by providing feedback only.

Question: What classroom modifications and supports will be helpful to an LCS student?

Answer: It is never expected that a professor modifies their course for an LCS student. However, one support that the LCS program practices and recommends is selecting a peer partner, who is a degree-seeking student, to work alongside the LCS student. Identification of a peer partner allows the LCS student to have a primary point of contact for the course and increases their social network. The LCS instructional staff will send an email prior to the start of the semester with additional information and request assistance in identifying a peer partner.

Question: What are other ways to support the LCS program and students?

Answer: An additional way to support the success of the LCS student in the classroom is by extending access to Moodle course materials to the academic support coordinator, _____ via the “tutor” role.

Another way to support the program is by sharing your experience working with the LCS program with other professionals within Calvin University and the greater community! Sharing your story helps to spread awareness of the program on campus, in addition to spotlighting the need for and success of inclusive programs in higher education.

Question: What additional supports are available?

Answer: LCS staff are always willing to provide one-on-one support when needed. In addition, LCS provides an annual training opportunity in Universal Design for Learning (UDL) that is open to all faculty and staff. Other learning opportunities are available throughout the year and advertised in Calvin News. To learn more, contact _____.